

ZIMBABWE

FEBRUARY 2015 – JULY 2026

Prepared by Africa INSIGHTS Research Team | Vertical: Travel & Tourism

Zimbabwe's travel perception has climbed 24 points since 2015, driven by world-class scenery — but hospitality drift and a sharp 2024 dip demand immediate attention.

1,186	68%	14%	18%	68/100
RECORDS IN VIEW	POSITIVE	NEUTRAL	NEGATIVE	PERCEPTION

Positive, neutral and negative are shares of all 1,186 records in view. Perception is a 0-100 score where 50 is neutral.

01 2015 TO 2026 IN REVIEW

Zimbabwe's travel perception has undergone a **structural improvement** across the eleven-year span covered by this report, rising from a perception score of 42 in 2015 to 66 in 2026 — a net gain of 24 points. That arc is not linear: a peak of 78 in 2022 was followed by a marked retreat to 64 in 2024, and the partial recovery to 66 in 2026 remains well short of that high-water mark. The dominant engine of positive perception throughout the period has been scenery, which accounts for the largest share of theme mentions and commands the highest net sentiment of any reportable theme. The principal drag is hospitality, which carries a worsening trend across the two halves of the period.

The single finding that should govern this quarter's decisions is the **hospitality decline**. Scenery alone cannot sustain Zimbabwe's competitive position: the gap between the country's natural appeal and the quality of its human-facing experience is widening, and the evidence shows this is what converts admiration into hesitation.

The immediate action is to brief accommodation and front-line service operators on the specific complaints surfacing in visitor commentary, and to build a recovery narrative around Zimbabwean warmth and welcome — the same warmth that generated the highest-engagement positive voices in the data — before the 2024–2026 negativity trend solidifies into a reputational default.

DATA NOTE

Year-level records for 2015 (12 records) and 2017 (21 records) fall below the 50-record minimum sample threshold and should be read as directional indicators rather than robust annual benchmarks.

DATA NOTE

The period label runs to July 2026; the 2026 annual figure therefore represents only a partial year and may shift materially as the year completes.

02 PERCEPTION OVERVIEW

Zimbabwe scores **68 on the 0–100 perception scale**, where 50 is neutral, across 1,186 records in view. Net sentiment stands at **50.5**, meaning positive records outnumber negative ones by that margin. Of all records in view, **68% are positive**, **14% are neutral**, and **18% are negative**. That distribution places Zimbabwe firmly in net-positive territory, but the 18% negative share is large enough to carry reputational weight, particularly given the high engagement scores on the most critical comments in the dataset.

The positive-to-neutral ratio is instructive. A 14% neutral share is relatively modest, which means the market is not ambivalent about Zimbabwe — it has formed opinions, and those opinions lean positive. The risk, however, lies in the concentration of that positivity. Scenery alone dominates the positive conversation; where visitors venture beyond landscape commentary into service, infrastructure, and social conditions, the tone shifts and the negative share rises. A perception score that rests on a single pillar is inherently fragile.

Emotional texture reinforces this reading. **34% of all records in view** carry an excited emotion signal, and **6% carry longing** — a combination that speaks to aspiration and desire to visit rather than post-trip satisfaction. Only **2% register disappointment** and **1% register fear**, which suggests that active safety anxiety is not yet a mainstream perception problem, even if safety sentiment is gradually worsening in the second half of the period. The task for the tourism board is to convert that excitement and longing into arrivals before negative structural narratives gain further ground.

DATA NOTE

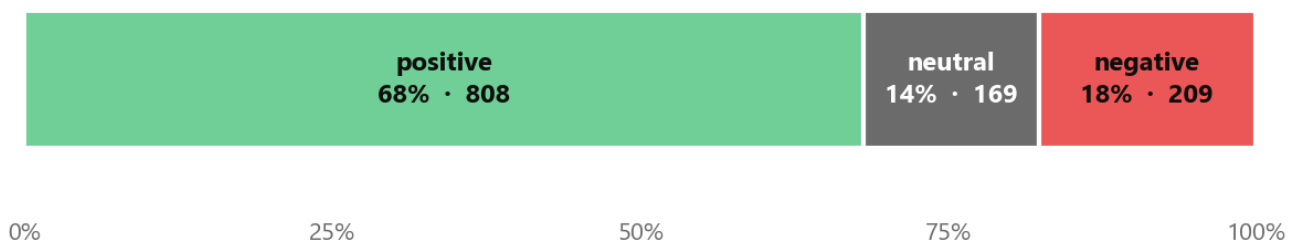
Content attribution stands at 90% of all records in view, meaning a small share of records could not be attributed to a named source or author — this does not materially affect the overall picture.

DATA NOTE

Emotion figures are drawn from a subset of records carrying identifiable emotional signals and should be read as relative proportions of the full view rather than a census of all visitor emotions.

Figure 1 — Sentiment breakdown

How the 1,186 records in view split across sentiment classes; each share is a percentage of all records in view. Net sentiment is +50 points.



03 THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Scenery is Zimbabwe's dominant and most stable asset. With 356 mentions — the most of any reportable theme — and 90% of those mentions positive, scenery generates a net sentiment of 81.7, far above any other theme in the dataset. The positive signal is unambiguous and consistent across the period. @hariyemadzimambo4259 captured the aspirational quality of this response in November 2022: **"I never knew zimbabwe was this beautiful man, thank you for showing us how Africans are living large in Africa."** Crucially, even the critical voice on scenery does not dispute the beauty of the country — @TheKingsGuard-c6g wrote in August 2025, **"I come from Uganda. And I'm here to just mention that a country can be beautiful and still be a nightmare to its people."** That comment is a warning: scenery positivity is robust, but it coexists with a perception that the lived experience of Zimbabwe falls short of its landscape promise.

Hospitality is the most consequential problem theme. It is the second-most-mentioned reportable theme at 128 mentions, but only 58% of those mentions are positive and 34% are negative — a net of just 23.4. More importantly, hospitality is the only reportable theme whose negative trajectory across the two halves of the period clears the evidence threshold: negativity among hospitality mentions worsened measurably between the first and second halves of the full period. The positive side of the conversation is warm and personal: @Lsgworx wrote in July 2022, **"Im South African and I can tell you that Zimbabwe has the most hard working and intelligent people, also very kind."** But the negative side carries significant reach: @Boomslang1's October 2023 comment — **"Zimbabwe has been battered by mainstream media for over 20 years because we took our land back. We're still under economic sanctions and things are really tough for most people but we're holding on"** — attracted 1,377 engagements and frames Zimbabwe's hospitality challenge as inseparable from its economic and political narrative. Tourism messaging must directly address this framing.

Wildlife commands attention but carries a material negative share. Sixty mentions of wildlife yield a net of 30.0, with 28% of those mentions negative — the joint-highest negativity rate among all reportable themes alongside safety. The positive comments are vivid and evocative: @tindo9833 wrote in September 2021, **"Never ceases to amaze me how such a big animal just seems to melt into the bush. Once saw a herd of elephants cross the road in Hwange, Zimbabwe and in less than a minute they had disappeared into the thicket. Almost by magic."** Negative wildlife commentary centres on resource and conservation concerns, as in @robbabcock_'s October 2021 remark: **"How sad! Bezos has that much money in his couch cushions but for lack of pocket change Zimbabwe can't move the troublesome elephants."** The conservation funding narrative is an active reputational liability that wildlife-led campaigns must pre-empt.

Safety is a manageable but worsening risk. Among the 23 mentions of safety — which meet the reportable threshold — 52% are positive but 35% are negative. The positive end includes direct endorsements of safe travel, such as @andrepitout3311's November 2021 message: **"Enjoy your travels through Africa. It is the best continent to visit & enjoy the natural beauty. Safe travels on your motorbike."** The negative signal, while not yet dominant, is moving in the wrong direction across the period. Safety is a gatekeeping theme: no amount of scenery excellence will overcome safety anxiety for first-time visitors, and the upward negativity trend warrants monitoring and proactive counter-messaging. Transport, with 35 mentions and 66% positive, generates the highest net sentiment of any service-related theme; however, the critical transport voice — @photonfantastic's August 2024 description of witnessing "the extent of the decay" on the Harare–Victoria Falls rail route — drew 2,500 engagements and signals that infrastructure decline is a high-visibility concern.

DATA NOTE

Five themes — water, weather, electricity, housing, and cost — fall below the 15-mention minimum threshold and are excluded from headline findings; their signals are directional only.

DATA NOTE

The safety theme's movement across the two halves of the period does not clear the reportable threshold for trend data, so directional wording is used without a specific point-change figure.

DATA NOTE

Transport's trend movement also does not meet the reportable threshold for half-period comparisons and is described qualitatively rather than numerically.

Voices behind the numbers — by theme

For each headline theme, the highest-engagement supportive and critical comment that raised it, with its sentiment and a link to the source. Emoji and non-Latin characters are stripped for print.

SCENERY · **POSITIVE** · @hariyemadzimambo4259 · Nov 2022 · 375 likes · score +0.76 · [YouTube comments](#)

"I never knew zimbabwe was this beautiful man, thank you for showing us how Africans are living large in Africa"

SCENERY · **NEGATIVE** · @TheKingsGuard-c6g · Aug 2025 · 233 likes · score -0.37 · [YouTube comments](#)

"I come from Uganda. And I'm here to just mention that a country can be beautiful and still be a nightmare to its people. I come in peace."

HOSPITALITY · **POSITIVE** · @Lsgworx · Jul 2022 · 846 likes · score +0.70 · [YouTube comments](#)

"Im South African and I can tell you that Zimbabwe has the most hard working and intelligent people, also very kind"

HOSPITALITY · **NEGATIVE** · @Boomslang1 · Oct 2023 · 1,377 likes · score -0.60 · [YouTube comments](#)

"Zimbabwe has been battered by mainstream media for over 20 years because we took our land back. We're still under economic sanctions and things are really tough for most people but we're holding on. Most Zimbabweans have never even been to Victoria Falls but thank you for showing that Zimbabwe is n..."

WILDLIFE · **POSITIVE** · @tindo9833 · Sep 2021 · 616 likes · score +0.31 · [YouTube comments](#)

"Never ceases to amaze me how such a big animal just seems to melt into the bush. Once saw a herd of elephants cross the road in Hwange, Zimbabwe and in less than a minute they had disappeared into the thicket. Almost by magic"

WILDLIFE · **NEGATIVE** · @robbabcock_ · Oct 2021 · 9 likes · score -0.93 · [YouTube comments](#)

"How sad! Bezos has that much money in his couch cushions but for lack of pocket change Zimbabwe can't move the troublesome elephants."

TRANSPORT · **POSITIVE** · @tindo9833 · Sep 2021 · 616 likes · score +0.31 · [YouTube comments](#)

"Never ceases to amaze me how such a big animal just seems to melt into the bush. Once saw a herd of elephants cross the road in Hwange, Zimbabwe and in less than a minute they had disappeared into the thicket. Almost by magic"

TRANSPORT · **NEGATIVE** · @photonfantastic · Aug 2024 · 2,500 likes · score -0.79 · [YouTube comments](#)

"I was born and raised in Rhodesia then Zimbabwe. I left the country permanently in 1992 and haven't returned to visit since 2001. As a young man, I travelled by train from Harare to Victoria Falls and back. It is painful to witness the extent of the decay. Thank you for making this video."

The loudest voices overall

The most-engaged supportive and critical mentions anywhere in this view, whatever theme they raise.

POSITIVE · @johnajah4752 · Mar 2022 · 959 likes · score +0.82 · [YouTube comments](#)

"I am Nigerian and seriously looking forward to visiting Zimbabwe maybe with family or students on excursion one day.....Love your guys Zimbabweans"

POSITIVE · @Lsgworx · Jul 2022 · 846 likes · score +0.70 · [YouTube comments](#)

"Im South African and I can tell you that Zimbabwe has the most hard working and intelligent people, also very kind"

NEGATIVE · @realityDUBSTEP · Aug 2024 · 5,248 likes · score -0.85 · [YouTube comments](#)

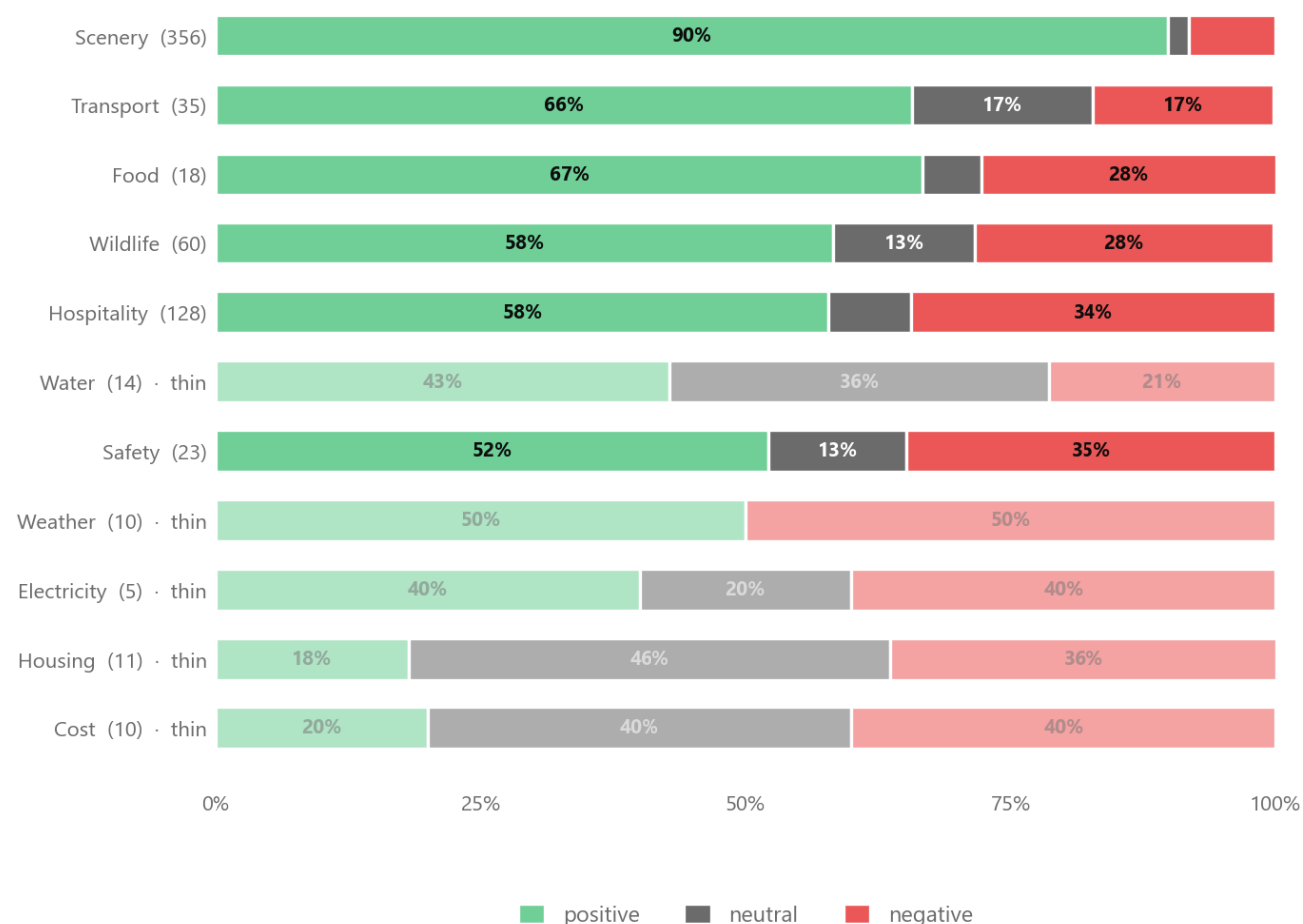
"How can poverty exist in Zimbabwe if everyone is a trillionaire?"

NEGATIVE · @groovedive1 · Aug 2024 · 3,299 likes · score -0.83 · [YouTube comments](#)

"I wonder if in 30 years someone as yourself will be visiting England and wondering why it has become a forgotten ghost town."

Figure 2 — Sentiment by theme

Every travel theme mentioned in this view, ranked by net sentiment. Each bar is a percentage of that theme's own mentions, not of the whole view, so bars are not comparable in volume. Mention counts in brackets; themes below the 15-mention floor are faded and marked thin.



04 VISITOR SEGMENTS

Visitor segments in this dataset are inferred from the language of the comments themselves — based on recurring keywords associated with particular travel styles — rather than declared by the visitor. A record that does not use the relevant vocabulary goes unclassified, which is why only **8% of all records in view** carry a segment tag. The findings below describe how Zimbabwe reads among those who write in a recognisably adventure, budget, business, or luxury register; they do not represent a census of who actually visits.

Adventure travellers are the only cohort that meets the 50-record threshold for robust analysis, with 74 records and a perception score of 65. Among those records, **61% are positive and 27% are negative** — a net sentiment of 33.8. That profile is noticeably less positive than Zimbabwe's overall score of 68, suggesting that visitors who engage with safaris, national parks, and trekking experiences encounter frictions — likely wildlife management concerns and infrastructure gaps on access routes — that temper their enthusiasm relative to the broader visitor base. The perception score of 65, while solidly positive, also sits below the overall country score, reinforcing the case for targeted investment in adventure-trail quality and conservation storytelling. No other cohort clears the evidence threshold for direct comparison, so cross-segment ranking is not possible from this data.

DATA NOTE

Only one visitor cohort — adventure — meets the 50-record minimum threshold. Budget (6 records), business (6 records), and luxury (3 records) cohorts are too small for reportable findings and cannot be compared against the adventure cohort or against each other.

DATA NOTE

The classified share of 8% of all records in view means that the large majority of records carry no segment tag; cohort findings are directional evidence for targeting, not a measurement of the visitor population.

Table 1 — Visitor segments

Share of all records is that cohort's share of every record in view; perception and net sentiment are computed within the cohort itself. Cohorts below the 50-record floor are faded and marked thin.

VISITOR SEGMENT	RECORDS	SHARE OF ALL RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET
Adventure	74	6%	65/100	+34
Budget · thin	6	<1%	40/100	-33
Business · thin	6	<1%	67/100	+50
Luxury · thin	3	<1%	32/100	-33

HOW VISITOR SEGMENTS ARE INFERRED

Visitor segments are inferred from the language of each comment, not declared by the visitor. Every record is scanned for a fixed keyword list per travel style — adventure (safari, hiking, national park, trekking), luxury (resort, spa, five-star, private guide), business (conference, layover, coworking, work trip) and budget (hostel, backpacking, street food, affordable) — and is tagged with whichever style it uses the most distinct keywords of; ties break in a fixed order. A record that matches nothing is left unclassified rather than assigned a style, which is why the classified share is well short of every record in view. Read the cohorts accordingly. They describe records that talk a certain way, not a surveyed population: a visitor who never names their travel style is invisible to the tagger, a luxury traveller complaining about a hostel reads as budget, and the keyword lists are English-only, so non-English comments are under-classified. Cohort figures are directional evidence for targeting, not a measurement of who visits.

05 COMPETITIVE BENCHMARKING

Zimbabwe ranks **6th out of 10 reportable peer markets** on overall perception, with a score of 68. The leader, Tanzania, scores 73 — a gap of 5 points. Ghana, Rwanda, and Senegal each score 70, and Kenya scores 69, all ahead of Zimbabwe. South Africa (65), Egypt (64), and Nigeria (62) trail Zimbabwe, as does Morocco (39) among reportable markets. Zimbabwe's positive rate of **68% of all records in view** is broadly competitive with the upper tier — Rwanda posts 70% positive and Tanzania 71% — but Zimbabwe's negative rate of **18% of all records in view** is higher than Tanzania's 12% and Kenya's 15%, which is where the ranking gap is actually generated. Closing the negativity gap, rather than amplifying positivity, is the more efficient path to moving up the peer table.

On the two themes where reportable cross-country gaps exist, Zimbabwe's position is unexpectedly strong. On **transport**, Zimbabwe's net sentiment of 48.6 is 49.7 points ahead of the peer average net of -1.1 — a substantial and significant lead. This likely reflects the aspirational and scenic quality of the country's major road and rail corridors when they are functioning, versus a peer set where urban congestion and road safety dominate the transport conversation. On **safety**, Zimbabwe's net of 17.4 is 22.0 points ahead of the peer average net of -4.6, a counterintuitive advantage given the country's reputational challenges on security. This suggests that visitors who actually travel to Zimbabwe experience and report safety conditions more favourably than the pre-trip reputation would predict — a finding the tourism board should amplify actively in pre-travel communications. The wildlife gap between Zimbabwe and its peers does not clear the reportable threshold of 10 points and is not stated here.

DATA NOTE

Cameroon's benchmark record count of 16 falls below the 50-record minimum and is excluded from comparative analysis.

DATA NOTE

The Morocco figure is based on 52 records, which clears the minimum threshold but represents a thin sample relative to other peers and should be interpreted with caution.

DATA NOTE

Theme-level peer gaps are available only for transport, safety, wildlife, scenery, food, and hospitality; the wildlife and scenery gaps do not clear the 10-point reportable threshold and are not stated as findings.

MARKET	RECORDS	PERCEPTION	NET SENTIMENT
Tanzania	1,326	73/100	+59
Ghana	1,094	70/100	+52
Rwanda	1,526	70/100	+54
Senegal	1,114	70/100	+50
Kenya	2,075	69/100	+52
Zimbabwe	1,186	68/100	+50
South Africa	2,164	65/100	+39
Egypt	2,305	64/100	+36
Nigeria	1,884	62/100	+33
Morocco	52	39/100	-21

Zimbabwe's perception trajectory over the full period tells a story of **strong recovery followed by a worrying reversal**. The score rose from 42 in 2015 to a peak of 78 in 2022, a gain of 36 points across seven years. That ascent was broad and sustained, with the negative rate falling from 50% of all records in 2015 to just 8% of all records in 2022. The 2022 peak coincided with the highest record volume of any year in the dataset that cleared the reporting threshold at that time, suggesting both growing international interest in Zimbabwe and a positive experience cycle feeding itself.

The **2024 contraction is the period's clearest signal**. The perception score fell to 64 and the negative rate rose to 20% of all records in 2024, after sitting at 9% in 2023. That is a reversal of a magnitude that exceeds drift: it represents a genuine shift in how visitors and observers were discussing Zimbabwe at that moment. The highest-engagement negative comments in the dataset — including @realityDUBSTEP's August 2024 remark on poverty and hyperinflation, which attracted 5,248 engagements, and @photonfantastic's 2,500-engagement lament over infrastructure decay — are anchored in that year, confirming that 2024 was a period when structural economic and infrastructure concerns broke into mainstream travel conversation with unusual force.

The **2025–2026 partial recovery to 67 and 66 respectively** is encouraging but incomplete. The negative rate has retreated from 20% in 2024 to 17% in 2025 and 20% again in 2026, suggesting the recovery is not yet durable. Hospitality — the only reportable theme with a confirmed worsening trend across the two halves of the full period — is the most likely structural anchor of this plateau. Scenery, by contrast, is stable: its negative rate moved only marginally across the two halves, confirming it as a reliable base rather than an active driver of improvement. The implication is that further gains in perception score will require service-side intervention, not additional scenery-led content.

DATA NOTE

Annual records for 2015 (12), 2016 (34), and 2017 (21) fall below the 50-record minimum threshold; their perception scores and negative rates are directional only and should not be ranked or compared numerically with confidence.

DATA NOTE

The 2026 figure covers only the period to July 2026 and is a partial-year observation; the final annual figure may differ materially.

DATA NOTE

Theme-level trend data (aspect_movement) carries reportable flags only for hospitality (worsening) and scenery (stable); all other theme movements are directional and not stated as confirmed trends.

Figure 3 — Perception over time (by year)

Perception score per period on a 0–100 scale, where 50 is neutral.

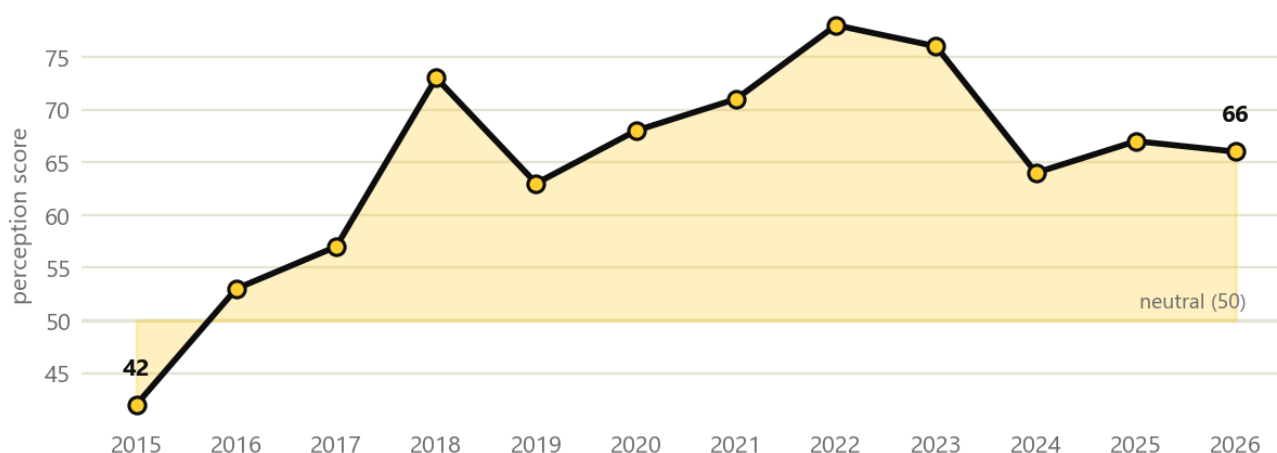
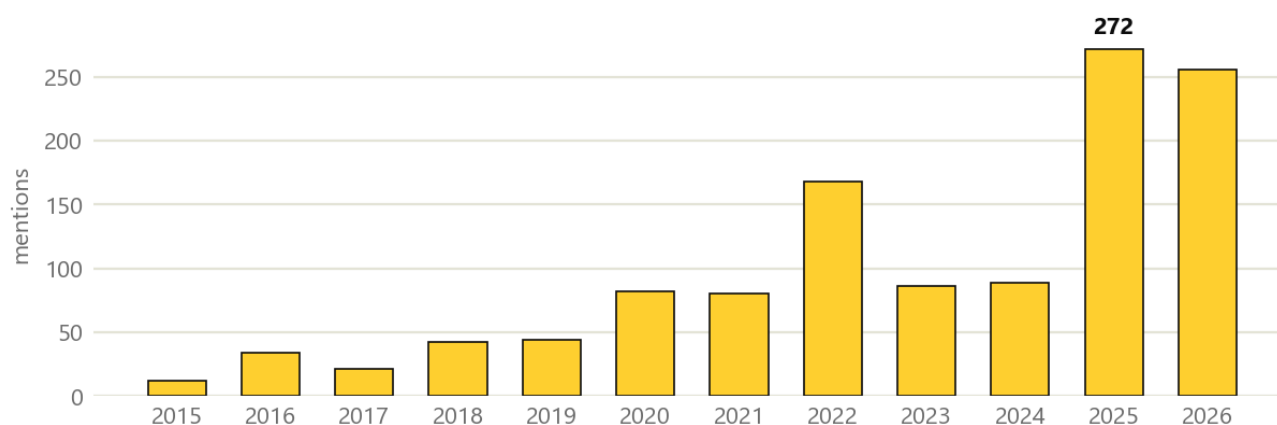


Figure 4 — Conversation volume (by year)

Records per period. Read the trend above against this: a swing on thin volume is noise.



07 RECOMMENDATIONS

The hospitality worsening trend — the only reportable theme-level deterioration in the dataset — should trigger immediate operator engagement. The tourism board should convene front-line hospitality operators, lodge managers, and tour guides in Harare and Victoria Falls and share the specific negative commentary driving this decline, particularly the narrative that economic hardship is degrading the visitor experience. The goal is not to suppress the economic reality but to equip operators to channel it into the warmth and resilience story that the high-engagement positive voices — such as @Lsgworx's July 2022 comment on Zimbabweans being "the most hard working and intelligent people, also very kind" — already demonstrate is available and credible. The target audience for this briefing is accommodation and ground-transport operators rather than the marketing function.

The **transport and safety peer advantages** — Zimbabwe leads its peer group by 49.7 points on transport net sentiment and 22.0 points on safety net sentiment, both at the reportable gap threshold — are being systematically undersold. Pre-travel perception of Zimbabwe on safety is widely assumed to be negative, yet visitors who travel there report safety more favourably than the peer average. The tourism board should build a dedicated pre-trip reassurance layer into its digital presence — targeted at travellers in the consideration phase — that leads with verified visitor accounts of safe, well-connected travel rather than defensive denials of risk. The primary channel for this is the YouTube content ecosystem, which accounts for 100% of the effective record base in this view.

The **adventure segment's perception gap** — a score of 65 against the overall country score of 68, with 27% of adventure-coded records negative — points to a specific friction in the safari and national park experience, most likely linked to wildlife management concerns and access infrastructure. The Zimbabwe Tourism Authority and Zimparks should co-fund content that directly addresses the conservation funding narrative surfaced in comments like @robbabcock_'s October 2021 remark about elephant management, and should place that content with high-reach adventure-travel creators whose audiences match the 74-record adventure cohort. This is a targeted spend, not a broad campaign.

Finally, the **2024 negativity spike** — driven by high-engagement economic and infrastructure commentary — established a set of reference videos and comment threads that continue to surface in search and recommendation feeds. The board cannot delete those conversations, but it can displace them. Commissioning updated, high-production-value content that documents genuine improvements in the Harare–Victoria Falls corridor — directly countering @photonfantastic's August 2024 lament about rail decay, which drew 2,500 engagements — would introduce competing evidence into the same algorithm that amplified the negative signal. The objective is not to win the argument in comments but to change what a prospective visitor sees first.

DATA NOTE

Specific figures for budget, business, and luxury segments are not available at reportable sample sizes; recommendations for those segments cannot be evidence-grounded from this dataset and are therefore omitted.

DATA NOTE

No cost or value-for-money theme clears the 15-mention reportable threshold; recommendations on pricing strategy cannot be supported by this data.

08 METHODOLOGY & PROVENANCE

Country	Zimbabwe
Year range	2015–2026
Aspect (any of)	all aspects
Sentiment	positive, neutral, negative
Data source	all
Relevant records only	yes
Period	February 2015 – July 2026
Records	1,186
Generated	02 Sep 2026 13:08 UTC
Narrative	Written by claude-sonnet-4-6; every figure verified against the computed data.

Evidence base: 1,185 YouTube comments, 1 YouTube transcript segment. 90% of all records in view were attributed to this market from what the text itself is about rather than from the query that surfaced them. Percentages are written as whole numbers throughout, and each is stated with what it is a share of: sentiment shares are of all records in view, a theme's shares are of that theme's own mentions, and a cohort's shares are of the records in that cohort. Shares on different denominators are not comparable with one another. Visitor segments are inferred from the language of each comment, not declared by the visitor. Every record is scanned for a fixed keyword list per travel style — adventure (safari, hiking, national park, trekking), luxury (resort, spa, five-star, private guide), business (conference, layover, coworking, work trip) and budget (hostel, backpacking, street food, affordable) — and is tagged with whichever style it uses the most distinct keywords of; ties break in a fixed order. A record that matches nothing is left unclassified rather than assigned a style, which is why the classified share is well short of every record in view. Read the cohorts accordingly. They describe records that talk a certain way, not a surveyed population: a visitor who never names their travel style is invisible to the tagger, a luxury traveller complaining about a hostel reads as budget, and the keyword lists are English-only, so non-English comments are under-classified. Cohort figures are directional evidence for targeting, not a measurement of who visits. Sentiment is scored by a multilingual transformer; themes, emotion and visitor segment are rule-based taggers. Evidence thresholds: 50 records for a reliable view, 15 mentions before a theme can headline a finding, 5 points before a theme counts as praised or criticised, 10 points before a cross-country

gap is stated. Every figure in this report is computed from the filtered records by the analysis pipeline. The written analysis interprets those figures; each number it states is verified back against them before publication, and any section that fails verification is replaced by the deterministic summary.